

shallow lakes disappear. Plants, including tree species, tend to grow where water flow is slow along stream and river banks or on islands in river channels. However, plants, such as water hyacinth, can cover large areas of fresh water. Animals may be confined to water—fish, for example—while others spend only part of their life there, including frogs, hippopotamuses, and dragonflies. Each species occupies a particular habitat, and together they create a distinct community unique to that particular river or lake.

Mangroves

Restricted to tropical and subtropical regions, mangrove swamps usually develop in intertidal areas on muddy shores, although some extend for some distance inland. Only mangrove trees can grow successfully in the waterlogged, salty mud and survive regular inundation by seawater. The different species have various adaptations that allow them to do this, including

having prop roots for additional support in soft sediment, and the ability to filter out salt as it enters their roots, or to store it in their leaves and lose it when the leaves are shed. Mangrove swamp is the most endangered of the world's habitats due to large scale removal in recent years to make way for aquatic farming of fish, crustaceans, and mollusks.

Oceans and seas

Although the world's oceans are interconnected, numerous seas, each with their own distinct characteristics, exist within them. The sunlit upper waters of the ocean have the most organisms, and coral reefs are among the most biodiverse. However, ecoregions also exist much deeper, with food chains based on organic material drifting down from above or on bacteria able to manufacture food using chemical reactions that do not need sunlight. Coastal regions are extremely harsh environments for wildlife as rocks and sandy shores are periodically exposed to the air, and buffeting by waves can damage and dislodge organisms unless they are firmly anchored. Oceans support a huge variety of life, ranging from microscopic algae that underpin oceanic food chains to the planet's largest living animal, the blue whale.



COASTS

Exposure to the air twice a day and buffeting by the waves are just two features of coastlines that make them the most demanding of all habitats to live in. On rocky shores, many animal species have shells for protection and to retain moisture.



CORAL REEFS

Coral reefs provide plenty of food and hiding places. This means that reef fish are usually colorful and come in a multitude of shapes and sizes as, unlike oceanic fish, they do not need to be streamlined and fast to hunt or escape from predators.



OPEN OCEAN

Most life in the open ocean is found at or just below the surface as this is where most of the food is produced. Despite the vast expanse of this habitat, only around 5 percent of the world's animal species live here.

